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Prehistory: The Emergence of Civilization in Early Myanmar

The history of Myanmar, formerly known as Burma, dates from prehistoric times to the present. The Mon, the Pyū, and the Arakanese settled throughout Lower Burma, as far as Chao Pya (Menam) valley on the middle branch of the Ayeyarwaddy valley and the Bay of Bengal, respectively, at different times in prehistory. Given the contested historical claims of the origins of the modern Myanmar state and the paucity of written records, much of Myanmar's prehistory is subject to conjecture. What is known about the prehistoric period comes from the limited number of artifacts found and excavations that have been carried out in Myanmar.

The first urban sites began to appear in Upper Myanmar, the Arakan alluvium, and around the Gulf of Martaban. They roughly date from the end of the first millennium BCE and are characterized by burnt brick walls situated near a river. Sometime between 2500 and 1500 BCE, the Mon made their way out of western China, eventually settling between the Thanlwin and Sittang Rivers, becoming the first-known inhabitants of what is now Myanmar. The Mons were not the only inhabitants of Myanmar for long. A few centuries later, a group of tribes that would become known as the Pyū arrived from the Tibetan Plateau. They were followed by the Burman, who would go on to found the first Burmese empire at Bagan.

EARLY HUMAN SETTLEMENT

Although archaeological exploration of one sort or another began in Myanmar over a century ago, our knowledge of the lives of the earliest human inhabitants remain sketchy. The initial Neolithic-age inhabitants of Myanmar were widely dispersed populations of small bands of kin-based